

How Nikon uses Rhetoric in the Stunning Nikon Ad Campaign

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Rhetoric is the way people communicate persuasively, and the tools they use to enhance their persuasion. There are a few ways to investigate that rhetoric. The main one we will be looking into is the “rhetorical situation,” which can be split into five main parts: Genre, rhetors, audience, constraints, and exigence (GRACE). Another way to look at rhetoric that needs to be discussed are the three “artistic appeals” created by Aristotle in the fourth century BCE. They are Logos, Pathos, and Ethos. Logos is appealing to logic and reason; Pathos is when the rhetoric is appealing to emotion; and Ethos is the way the rhetoric enhances the credibility and authority of the rhetor. (Carroll, 2010). It is important to understand these ways of understanding rhetoric, as they are necessary to deconstruct and understand the different rhetorical devices. I will be using these ideas to deconstruct the rhetoric of an advertisement.

In the November 2006 issue of *Macworld* magazine, page 31 features a full-page advertisement from Nikon. This ad is part of their Stunningnikon campaign, where Nikon sent two hundred cameras to the residents of Georgetown, South Carolina and used the resulting photos in their marketing material (Lippert, 2007).

Figure 1

Advertisement for Nikon



Note. The ad features a blurb in the middle of the page, talking about the people who took the photos, with a brief description of the camera used. Along with a link to the ad campaign's

website. The rest of the advertisement is four photos with webpage links featuring the first names of photographers.

This advertisement uses several aspects of the rhetorical situation to convince the reader that they should buy the Nikon D80. Nikon bought a full-page advertisement; they want you to see it, even if you skim. They show that the average Joe can take excellent pictures, even without technical skills. And they invite you to explore the camera further, with personal web links that add credibility to the exigence.

Defining GRACE and Using It to Deconstruct the Advertisement

Genre is the form the rhetoric takes: the language it uses, the way it is transmitted or communicated, its imagery. If it is an ad, is it on tv, or social media? An opinion piece could be in a newspaper, or a YouTube video essay. When discussing the purpose of pathos in rhetoric, Carroll (2010) states that “Emotional appeals can come in many forms – an anecdote or narrative, an image such as a photograph, or even humor” (p.53). Appeals; whether that be logical (logos) or emotional (pathos), take many different forms, and those forms would be the genre. For the genre, Nikon chose a full-page ad, featuring photos from the subjects in their campaign. For example, Heather’s cute dog or Timothy’s funky bench. They did this because it stands out better to their desired audience because it is eye catching and the photos are attractive. Once you have been sucked in, and you read some more, you find these awesome photos are not taken by professionals. This of course is what invites the audience to research more into the camera, and Nikon the company. The web links all over the advertisement help this idea because they make it super simple to get a ton of marketing material from Nikon; without Nikon needing to buy all the advertising space in the magazine. Though it is important to note that Nikon is serious about this campaign, as page 29 and 33 of this issue of *Macworld* are also full-page

advertisements in the Stunningnikon campaign. Closely related to the genre is the audience, as often the genre is chosen to cater to the audience. The audience is those on the receiving end of the rhetoric. The audience does not have to be the intended audience; it includes anyone who would want to engage in rhetoric. “Another part of the rhetorical context is audience, those who are the (intended or unintended) recipients of the rhetorical message.” “In other words, the audience should be able to help address the problem” (Carroll, 2010, p.49). Now to look at the ad through this lens, its primary audience is amateur photographers. Those who do it as more of a hobby, it is not their job, so they most likely lack the skill to effectively use other, more expensive models. Those who “shoot for family photo albums” Nikon (2006).

The second part of GRACE is rhetors; they are the people making and broadcasting rhetoric. They are the ones who want you to be persuaded by something. Carroll (2010) supports this idea when explaining purpose as part of the ‘rhetorical triangle’: “We can discern the purpose by asking questions like ‘what does the rhetor want me to believe after seeing this message?’ or ‘what does the rhetor want me to do?’” (p.52). The primary rhetor is Nikon, since they are the ones who made the ad. Per Nikon’s website, their imaging business brings “enjoyment to people around the world” and that their cameras “capture crucial moments in high-quality images” (*Imaging Products Business | Corporate Information | Nikon about Us*, n.d.). Nikon wants you to buy the D80, so you too can have your crucial moments captured in high-quality. Because they bought the ad spot, that makes them the primary rhetor. But they are not the only rhetor. Because the ad is in a magazine, the magazine is also a rhetor because they are the ones who are transmitting the advertisement. *Macworld*, by its name, is primarily targeted towards Macintosh users. Apple, which manufactures the Macintosh line of products, has a reputation as a luxury, but friendly brand. “Apple’s innovation is driven by its design-first

philosophy, which prioritizes the user experience and seeks to create products that are not only functional but also transformative.” (Aksu, 2024, Innovation Through Design: Pushing Boundaries section). Lastly, some more minor rhetors are the people whose photographs are being featured. And a bit more abstract, the emotional appeal that a cute dog has. These photos are being used to show the quality of the camera, even when used by amateur photographers.

Constraints, the fourth part of GRACE, are the ways the rhetoric will be changed to persuade the intended audience more effectively, based on the limitations with the transmission of the rhetoric. The rhetors need to be able to adapt their rhetoric for different situations: [constraints] “may be far more complex like the kinds of language you need to use to persuade a certain community.” (Carroll, 2010, p. 49). The most important physical constraint the advertisement has is the space that can be used for photographs. It is worth noting though, of the three Stunningnikon advertisements featured in this issue of *Macworld*; the balance between text and photos is the most balanced. This one has an effective paragraph, but also attractive photos that still manage to take up most of the space. In the part “What did they capture with the new 10.2 megapixel Nikon® D80™? See more of the jaw-dropping highlights” (Nikon, 2006). It props up the technical specs of the camera by directly using the megapixel number of the image sensor. Then after asking what the photographers captured, they say the highlights are “jaw-dropping.” That is certainly a strong endorsement, and why it is effective support of the rhetoric the advertisement is using. One unusual constraint that has appeared, now that this Nikon advertisement will be 20 years old in a few months, is that “stunningnikon.com” is not a domain that is owned by Nikon anymore. So, unless you have heard of tools like the Wayback Machine (<https://web.archive.org>), you are not going to be able to see the other parts of the ad campaign. And even if you use the aforementioned tools, the web pages were designed with heavy use of

Adobe Flash. This makes the experience viewing the sites with modern web browsers less than smooth, thus limiting the effectiveness of the advertisement. Adobe (2021) blocked all flash content from running in their flash player software, along with dropping all support for the product. But aside from those constraints, another important constraint is that there were a lot of photos taken as part of the campaign. There might have been a lot of great photos to showcase in the full-page magazine advertisement, but they had to narrow down to just four to feature. Or on the flipside it could have been that these were a stretch to find. But according to one user on the photography review site *DPRReview*, “The pictures are good....nothing spectacular” (Maynard001, 2007). So, I suspect it was a matter of the former, not the latter. Another important point is that in that same post, Maynard001 (2007) states “I was so intrigued by the idea that I spent 20 minutes tooling around their website.” This proves that while the website is ineffective for promoting Nikon nowadays, during the good couple of years after the camera’s release, it very much was an effective tool.

The final part of GRACE, exigence, is the situation the rhetoric is trying to address. It could be some sort of problem. Maybe the rhetors are trying to convince you of something. Those would be the exigence. Exigence is the heart of rhetoric, what most people would think of when they imagine “rhetoric.” Carroll (2010) talks about this a bit in her essay “Backpacks vs. Briefcases: Steps toward Rhetorical Analysis”: “What is this rhetoric responding to?” “What might have happened to make the rhetor (the person who creates the rhetoric) respond in this way?” (pp. 48-49). The whole idea, the exigence of this advert, is that amateur photographers can get amazing photos from using this camera. “They shoot for photo sites like Flickr.™ They shoot for family photo albums” (Nikon, 2006). By emphasizing that the photographers in their campaign are not professionals, they show that anyone can be a good photographer with the

Nikon D80. That is the primary exigence Nikon uses to try to convince you to buy the camera. It also appeals to the ethos of the camera and Nikon. It is naturally very hard for a company to sell an expensive, enthusiast product to amateurs. But this is an effective way to get people interested in a product that may normally be too expensive for them; those people need to be convinced the product is not too much for them, and that it will not be junk. A closer look at the advertisement though, and another exigence is revealed. The web links all over the advertisement go to the product page of the camera. Which of course is a part of the Nikon website. So, once you are there, even if you do not want this specific camera, you are likely to come across another camera that would be of greater interest.

Conclusion

Overall, Nikon was effective in their rhetoric. At least for this example, the genre is not wasted and is used efficiently. The few full-page ads from Nikon in this issue of *Macworld* are eye-catching. And they balance the use of text and photos to not be dry but also to have substance beyond pretty pictures. Next, Nikon clearly understands their audience, and their ethos remains strong. Their cameras seem to take excellent photos, but Nikon does not appear pretentious or too expensive, which is appealing to amateurs. And this understanding of their intended audience is what makes them an effective rhetor. They use several different tools in the advertisement. These are large eye-catching photos, a paragraph to make the message clear, and web links to expand the limits of the advertisement beyond the page. For constraints, especially for the time, Nikon managed them well. People clearly wanted to use the websites, and they could not have been pulling their hair finding the photos to feature in the ad campaign. Even though, unfortunately, the web half of the rhetoric has been limited by age. Finally, for exigence, Nikon is clear but not deceiving. There are no distractions from the message. It is clean and fun,

complete with a cute dog to show that regular people are really the ones taking these attractive photographs. Nikon was successful with their rhetoric.

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